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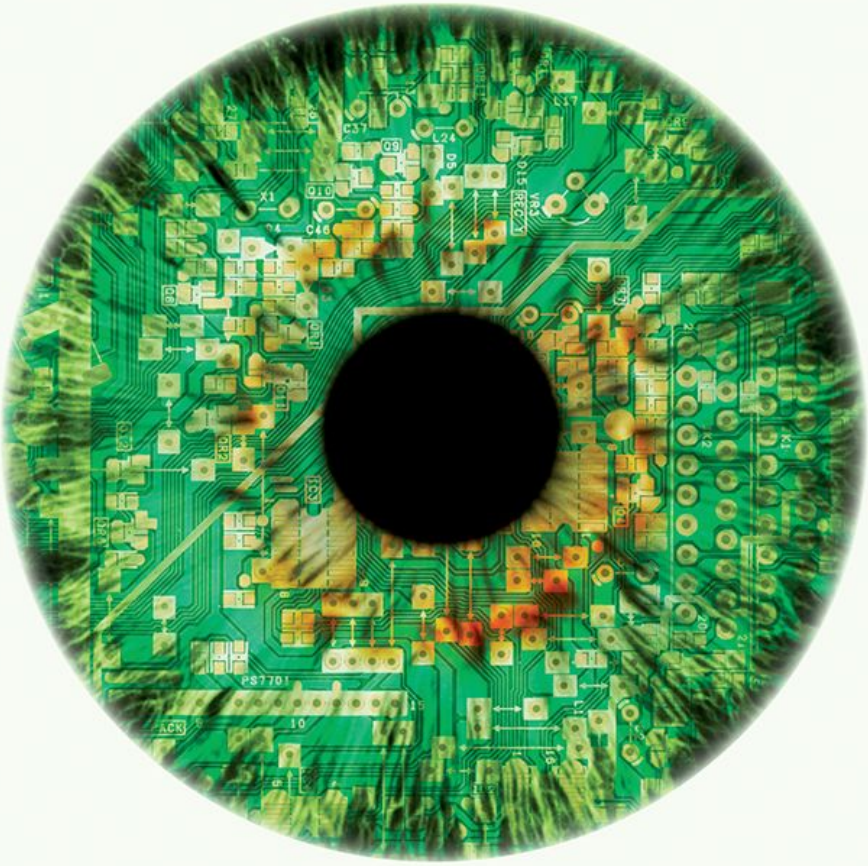

THE FUTURE OF THE PROFESSIONS

HOW TECHNOLOGY WILL TRANSFORM THE WORK OF HUMAN EXPERTS

THE FUTURE OF THE PROFESSIONS

Praise for *The Future of the Professions*

'A swashbuckling journey through the professions, this book makes sense of sweeping changes going on today and helps us see what it will mean to be a professional in an era of ubiquitous knowledge and increasingly capable machines. The authors' rigorous skepticism reveals an astounding future.'

Hugh Verrier, Chairman, White & Case

'Many books about the future are shallow and unnecessarily alarmist. This book is neither. We are behaving like ostriches in the developed world, refusing to see that technology is on the cusp of fundamentally reshaping professions. The future is bright, but only if we start embracing, rather than shunning, the future which the Susskinds show is hurtling towards us.'

Sir Anthony Seldon, Vice-Chancellor, University of Buckingham,
and former Master of Wellington College

'If you want to know how technology will continue to transform our lives, read this book! Well researched, beautifully written, comprehensive, insightful, and encouraging, the authors convincingly make the case that no profession is immune to these monumental changes, and that they provide an unprecedented opportunity for those who embrace rather than resist them.'

Professor Nicholas F. LaRusso, MD, Founding Medical Director
of the Mayo Clinic Center for Innovation

'In the tax profession we have seen transformational change, striking at the very foundations of what we do and how we do it. In this compelling work, the Susskinds help us think more clearly about the crucial issues and opportunities we face and set clear insight as to the way in which we must respond. Essential reading for anyone interested in the future of a professional organization.'

Conrad Young, Deloitte Global Leader, Tax Management Consulting

'Professions beware! In this insightful and thought-provoking book, Richard and Daniel Susskind capture the essence of today's changing environment where, whilst the destination may not be certain, it is clear the status quo will not survive. Technology in particular is having a profound impact across the professions and no group seems exempt. The future has never been so ripe with challenges and opportunities.'

Richard Sexton, Vice Chairman, Global Assurance, PwC

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RICHARD SUSSKIND

AND

DANIEL SUSSKIND

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We dedicate this book to the memory of
Shirley Susskind (1935–2015)
a very loving mother and grandmother

Preface

It is unusual for a father and son to write a book together. Before thanking the many people who helped us with this book, we thought readers would be interested to learn a little about the background to our collaboration.

A Note from Richard

For more than thirty years, I have been working on transforming the way that lawyers and courts work. I have written eight related books, and many of my theories about the future of legal services are no longer considered outrageous. Over the years, and around the world, at the end of my lectures to lawyers, I have been approached by stray doctors, auditors, architects, and many others who have said that my ideas apply equally to their own professions. I have had similar feedback in my consulting work with leading tax and audit specialists, and from my work as a university professor and school governor in the education sector. The starting-point for the research underpinning the book, therefore, is a well-tested and substantially corroborated set of ideas about the future of legal services that other professionals say resonates beyond law. One main purpose of the book is to test and extend this hypothesis about the law and lawyers to the professions more generally.

Above all, the project that led to this book has allowed me to work intensely with my son, Daniel. Very few fathers have this opportunity. It has been the high point of my working life.

A Note from Daniel

Five years have passed since my Dad and I first sat down to talk about this book. He had spent most of his career thinking about the future of the legal

profession. But, for a while, he had sensed that his thinking applied equally well elsewhere. At the time I was working in the Policy Unit in 10 Downing Street. As we talked, it became very clear that my experience in government confirmed his suspicions. And so we decided to set off on a project, together, to think about the future of the professions. It has been an extraordinarily happy five years, and a great privilege.

As Co-Authors

This book is written in the first person plural. This reflects the fact that our views are shared views, so that when we say that 'we believe', 'we see', or 'we predict', then our positions are indeed aligned. However, we accept that our use of 'we' in the past tense is sometimes anomalous. For example, where we speak of what we wrote in the mid-1980s, one of us (Daniel) was not yet alive. Nonetheless, as a convention throughout the book, when we speak of 'we', we may be referring, variously, to our joint views or experience or those of either one of us.

Acknowledgements

We have been fortunate to have had the help of a large number of people while writing this book. The following list comprises the many individuals who gave generously of their time to be interviewed, alongside numerous friends, colleagues, and clients who supported us throughout. To each and every one of you we extend our warmest thanks: David Agus, David Barnes, George Beaton, Lukas Biewald, Nick Birks, Bruce Braude, Jonathan Brayne, Steven Brill, Tim Brown, Simon Carne, Mark Chandler, Stacey Childress, Keith Coleman, Richard Collier-Keywood, Charles Conn, Dan Cooperman, Jim Dabney, John Danner, Ian Davis, Robin Downie, Matthew Edwards, Neville Eisenberg, Philip Evans, Alice Fermor-Hesketh, Gi Fernando, Cam Findlay, Daniel Finkelstein, Joshua Foer, Howard Gardner, Josh Glancy, Tom Goetz, Ian Goldin, Colin Gounden, Muir Gray, Ashok Gupta, Ben Hammersley, Mark Harris, Mike Hess, Silvia Hodges, Jonathan Hughes, Will Hunter, Michael Ingram, Ari Kaplan, Hanif Kara, John Kerr, Daphne Koller, Daniel Kraft, Kieran Kumaria, Adrian Lajtha, Nick LaRusso, Bill Liao, Paul Lippe, Ian Lloyd, Jay Lorsch, George Lowder, Bruce MacEwen, David Maister, James Manyika, Helen Margetts, Chris McKenna, Christopher Michel, Christopher Millard, Michael Mills, John Moore, David Morley, Tim Morris, Alastair Morrison, Gary Nelson, Howard Nichols, Cory Ondrejka, Chris Outram, Jonathan Oviatt, Alan Paterson, David Pester, Richard Punt, Stephen Rabinowitz, Chas Rampenthal, Paul Robinson, Joel Rose, Mari Sako, Viktor Mayer-Schönberger, Dov Seidman, Anthony Seldon, Richard Sennett, Richard Sexton, Tom Standage, Janet Stanton, Paloma Strelitz, Ziona Strelitz, Matt Sucherman, Stephen Swensen, Gideon Sylvester, Eric Topol, Darrel Untereker, David Vines, Vivek Wadhwa, Kent Walker, Ted Wang, Anthony Warrens, Rachel Whetstone, David Wilkins, Tom Wright, and Conrad Young.

A very big thank-you also to Darcy Hill for helping us so diligently with the bibliography, and to Patricia Cato and Suzanne Richmond for their assistance with early drafts of the book.

Our friends at Oxford University Press have been notably patient. David Musson has been an ongoing source of encouragement and of wise counsel; and we are grateful also at OUP to Kim Behrens, Kate Farquhar-Thomson, Phil Henderson, and Clare Kennedy for their enthusiasm and professionalism. Thank you also to Jeff New for his superb copy-editing.

The epigraph by John Maynard Keynes, *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money* (1936), © The Royal Economic Society, published by Cambridge University Press, is reproduced with permission.

Alan Susskind reviewed the entire manuscript. His observations and his ongoing support were very much appreciated. At the same time, Werner Susskind merits special mention for keeping us fully supplied with relevant articles from the *BMJ*.

Jamie Susskind deserves the largest thank-you of all. He was there for us constantly—to brainstorm, to motivate, to advise, and, occasionally, to mediate. He read two versions of the manuscript, and his detailed analysis and critique were invaluable.

Grace—I (Daniel) fear this will not be the last time. With all the love there is in the world, thank you for being there for me.

Alexandra—we thank you for your warmth, your smile, and your love. Michelle (our wife/mother)—you have been remarkable in your support of our work and your belief in us as co-authors. We cannot thank you enough for your love and endurance.

Finally, we dedicate this book to the memory of Shirley Susskind, our mother and grandmother. Very sadly, she passed away just a few weeks before we completed the manuscript. We know she would have been proud of us.

Richard Susskind
Daniel Susskind

Radlett, England
30 March 2015

Hitherto [1848] it is questionable if all the mechanical inventions yet made have lightened the day's toil of any human being. They have enabled a greater population to live the same life of drudgery and imprisonment, and an increased number of manufacturers and others to make fortunes. They have increased the comforts of the middle classes. But they have not yet begun to effect those great changes in human destiny, which it is in their nature and in their futurity to accomplish. Only when, in addition to just institutions, the increase of mankind shall be under the deliberate guidance of judicious foresight, can the conquests made from the powers of nature by the intellect and energy of scientific discoverers become the common property of the species, and the means of improving and elevating the universal lot.

John Stuart Mill

The difficulty lies, not in the new ideas, but in escaping from the old ones, which ramify, for those brought up as most of us have been, into every corner of our minds.

John Maynard Keynes

Contents

List of Boxes and Figure xv

Introduction 1

PART I. CHANGE

1. **The Grand Bargain** 9
   1.1 Everyday conceptions 10
   1.2 The scope of the professions 13
   1.3 Historical context 18
   1.4 The bargain explained 21
   1.5 Theories of the professions 23
   1.6 Four central questions 31
   1.7 Disconcerting problems 33
   1.8 A new mindset 37
   1.9 Some common biases 43
2. **From the Vanguard** 46
   2.1 Health 46
   2.2 Education 55
   2.3 Divinity 61
   2.4 Law 66
   2.5 Journalism 71
   2.6 Management consulting 78
   2.7 Tax and audit 84
   2.8 Architecture 94
3. **Patterns across the Professions** 101
   3.1 An early challenge 103
   3.2 The end of an era 104
   3.3 Transformation by technology 109
   3.4 Emerging skills and competences 114
   3.5 Professional work reconfigured 119
   3.6 New labour models 123
   3.7 More options for recipients 128
   3.8 Preoccupations of professional firms 134
   3.9 Demystification 140

PART II. THEORY

4. Information and Technology **145**
4.1 Information substructure 145
4.2 Pre-print and print-based communities 147
4.3 Technology-based Internet society 150
4.4 Future impact 153
4.5 Exponential growth in information technology 155
4.6 Increasingly capable machines 159
4.7 Increasingly pervasive devices 172
4.8 Increasingly connected humans 175
4.9 A fifty-year overview 182

5. Production and Distribution of Knowledge **188**
5.1 The economic characteristics of knowledge 189
5.2 Knowledge and the professions 193
5.3 The evolution of professional work 195
5.4 The drive towards externalization 202
5.5 The liberation of expertise: from craft to commons? 210
5.6 The decomposition of professional work 211
5.7 Production and distribution of expertise: seven models 215

PART III. IMPLICATIONS

6. Objections and Anxieties **231**
6.1 Trust, reliability, quasi-trust 233
6.2 The moral limits of markets 239
6.3 Lost craft 244
6.4 Personal interaction 248
6.5 Empathy 251
6.6 Good work 254
6.7 Becoming expert 258
6.8 No future roles 263
6.9 Three underlying mistakes 267

7. After the Professions **270**
7.1 Increasingly capable, non-thinking machines 272
7.2 The need for human beings 277
7.3 Technological unemployment? 284
7.4 The impact of technology on professional work 289
7.5 The question of feasibility 295

Conclusion: What Future Should We Want? **303**

Bibliography 309
Index 337

List of Boxes and Figure

Box 3.1. Patterns and trends 102
Box 4.1. Four main developments in information technology 155
Box 4.2. What connected humans do 176
Box 5.1. Models for the production and distribution of practical expertise 216
Box 6.1. Future roles 264

Figure 5.1. The evolution of professional work 197

Introduction

This book is about the professions and the systems and people that will replace them. Our focus is on doctors, lawyers, teachers, accountants, tax advisers, management consultants, architects, journalists, and the clergy (amongst others), on the organizations in which they work, and the institutions that govern their conduct. Our main claim is that we are on the brink of a period of fundamental and irreversible change in the way that the expertise of these specialists is made available in society. Technology will be the main driver of this change. And, in the long run, we will neither need nor want professionals to work in the way that they did in the twentieth century and before.

There is growing evidence that a transformation is already under way. More people signed up for Harvard's online courses in a single year, for example, than have attended the actual university in its 377 years of existence. In the same spirit, there are a greater number of unique visits each month to the WebMD network, a collection of health websites, than to all the doctors working in the United States. In the legal world, three times as many disagreements each year amongst eBay traders are resolved using 'online dispute resolution' than there are lawsuits filed in the entire US court system. On its sixth birthday, the *Huffington Post* had more unique monthly visitors than the website of the *New York Times*, which is almost 164 years of age. The British tax authorities use a fraud-detection system that holds more data than the British Library (which has copies of every book ever published in the UK). In 2014 the US tax authorities received electronic tax returns from almost 48 million people who had used online tax preparation software rather than a tax professional to help them. At WikiHouse, an online community designed a house that could be 'printed' and assembled for less than £50,000 (built successfully in London during September 2014). The architectural firm Gramazio & Kohler used a group of autonomous flying robots to assemble a structure out of 1,500 bricks. The

consulting firm Accenture has 750 hospital nurses on its staff, while Deloitte, founded as an audit practice 170 years ago, now has over 200,000 professionals and its own full-scale university set in a 700,000 square-foot campus in Texas. Meanwhile, the Pope has 19.3 million followers on Twitter; the Dalai Lama has a modest 10.4 million.[1]

Our broad argument

We believe that these developments are connected. They are early indicators of a transformation that we have been studying together since 2010, when we started work on this book. At that time, our main preoccupation was with the work of our current professions. However, as our research and thinking progressed, we concluded that a more basic and important question also had to be addressed—*how do we share expertise in society?* In what we term a 'print-based industrial society', the professions have played a central role in the sharing of expertise. They have been the main channel through which individuals and organizations have gained access to certain kinds of knowledge and experience. However, in a 'technology-based Internet society', we predict that increasingly capable machines, operating on their own or with non-specialist users, will take on many of the tasks that have been the historic preserve of the professions. We anticipate an 'incremental transformation' in the way that we produce and distribute expertise in society. This will lead eventually to a dismantling of the traditional professions.

For the current recipients and beneficiaries of the work of the professions, we bring the possibility of good tidings—of a world in which expertise is more accessible and affordable than ever before. For professional providers, although our thesis may seem threatening, we anticipate that a range of new opportunities will emerge. These are our hopes. But we also recognize that the new systems for sharing expertise could be misused, and we are troubled by this possibility. In any event, increasingly capable systems[2] will bring transformations to professional work that will resemble the impact of industrialization on traditional craftsmanship.

[1] See Chapters 2 and 3 for references and further details of these examples.

[2] We use the terms 'increasingly capable systems' and 'increasingly capable machines' interchangeably throughout the book. More generally, unless the context indicates otherwise, we also use 'systems' and 'machines' interchangeably.

To sceptics, who may already be tempted to put the book to one side, consider this: in the mid-1990s, when we predicted (in retrospect, rather unambitiously) that electronic mail would become the dominant way in which clients and lawyers would communicate, senior officials at the Law Society of England and Wales said that we should not be allowed to speak in public, that we failed to understand confidentiality, and that we were bringing the legal profession into disrepute. We recall this anecdote now in order to invite those who feel an intuitive distaste for our arguments to suspend disbelief for a short while and give serious contemplation to the notion that the future may look nothing at all like the past. Although some of the developments we anticipate in this book may seem outlandish today, none is more improbable than the idea of e-mail between lawyers and clients seemed in the mid-1990s.

Professionals play such a central role in our lives that we can barely imagine different ways of tackling the problems that they sort out for us. But the professions are not immutable. They are an artefact that we have built to meet a particular set of needs in a print-based industrial society. As we progress into a technology-based Internet society, however, we claim that the professions in their current form will no longer be the best answer to those needs. To pick out a few of their shortcomings—we cannot afford them, they are often antiquated, the expertise of the best is enjoyed only by a few, and their workings are not transparent. For these and other reasons, we believe today's professions should and will be displaced by feasible alternatives.

The professions as one object of study

Why study the professions as one phenomenon? Although they draw on different bodies of knowledge, their jargon varies, and their working practices can be quite diverse, we suggest that the professions have many features in common. Chief amongst these is that all professions, in analogous ways, are a solution to the same problem—that none of us has sufficient specialist knowledge to cope with all of our daily challenges. Human beings have limited understanding, and so we look to doctors, teachers, lawyers, and other professionals because they have expertise that we need to make progress in life. Professionals have knowledge, experience, skills, and know-how that those they help do not.

There are also practical reasons for considering a collection of professions together in one sweep. First of all, we believe that professions have much to learn from one another. Many have become increasingly introspective, driven into greater specialization, so that practitioners within a given profession often have a limited view of the work and achievements of their own colleagues, still less of the activities and progress in other disciplines. Our discussions with a wide range of professionals suggest that they find it enlightening and exciting to learn of advances in other fields, even if they are not immediate neighbours. They can draw analogies from the work of others and carry lessons learned into their own areas. More than this, professionals frequently see the potential and need for fundamental change in others more clearly than in themselves. Very often, after we give talks on our ideas, we are approached by individuals who argue that what we say applies right across the professions except in one field—their own. Lawyers, for example, tend to be quick to argue for a shake-up in our health and education services, but find it less apparent that legal services would benefit from major overhaul. In tackling a range of professions, our intention is to encourage practitioners from many fields to think more widely and strategically, and to be tolerant of the possibility of change in their own disciplines—a view of widened horizons elsewhere should broaden their perspective at home.

The structure of the book

Although our book is fairly ambitious in scope, there are many important issues that we have placed beyond its remit. We do not, for example, address questions of privacy, confidentiality, security, and liability. Nor do we consider the dark side of the Internet and the many nefarious uses to which, regrettably, our systems are being put. We regard these as vital issues that we hope others can pursue in the context of the professions.

We should also stress that our case studies and experience are largely Anglo-American, and to that extent our theories and predictions may be limited in their reach. That said, informal discussions and client work in India, China, and Australia suggest that our thinking about the future could be applied in most countries with little adaptation.

The book is organized in three main parts. In the first, we explore *change* in the professions. In Chapter 1 we consider the place of professionals in

society, the problems with the current set-up, and a variety of theories of the professions. Then we call for a new mindset. Drawing on our own research, in Chapter 2 we bring evidence from the frontiers of striking changes that are already observable across a wide range of professions. In Chapter 3 we capture these changes alongside our experiences from consulting and policy work as a set of patterns and trends across the professions.

In the second part of the book our focus is on *theory*. In systematic and general terms, we try to make sense of the shifts we are seeing and anticipating. In Chapter 4 we show that shifts in the way we store and communicate information have a direct impact on how we share expertise in society, and we anticipate four sets of remarkable developments in technology. We analyse knowledge in economic terms in Chapter 5, which leads us to show how professional work is evolving and to propose six new models for the production and distribution of expertise.

Finally, in the third part, we discuss the *implications* of our research and theoretical work. In Chapter 6 we lay out and respond to a wide range of objections to the future we anticipate. And, in Chapter 7, we address several major topics—the potential and limitations of increasingly capable machines, the impact of technology on employment, and whether emerging models of sharing expertise are in fact feasible. We conclude by asking and answering the question—what future should we want?

PART I

Change

I

The Grand Bargain

There are two possible futures for the professions. The first is reassuringly familiar. It is a more efficient version of what we already have today. On this model, professionals continue working much as they have done since the middle of the nineteenth century, but they heavily standardize and systematize their routine activities. They streamline their old ways of working. The second future is a very different proposition. It involves a transformation in the way that the expertise of professionals is made available in society. The introduction of a wide range of increasingly capable systems will, in various ways, displace much of the work of traditional professionals. In the short and medium terms, these two futures will be realized in parallel. In the long run, the second future will dominate, we will find new and better ways to share expertise in society, and our professions will steadily be dismantled. That is the conclusion to which this book leads.

The first step in our argument involves taking stock of the professions we currently have. We do this, in this opening chapter, to provide a foundation of solid thinking about the professions—about their purpose and common features, their strengths and weaknesses—upon which we build later. We start by sketching an informal portrait of today's professions. We follow this with a more systematic attempt to explain which occupational groups belong to the professions and why. We then discuss the history of the professions and look at the 'grand bargain', the traditional arrangement that grants professionals both their special status and their monopolies over numerous areas of human activity. Next, we reflect on various theoretical accounts of the professions, which leads us to identify a series of fundamental problems with our professions as currently organized. We close with a call for a new mindset, and point to a series of biases that are likely to inhibit professionals from thinking freely about their future.

1.1. Everyday conceptions

To set off at an easy pace, we begin with a set of non-theoretical, everyday views about the professions. On reflection, most people would say that the professions are at the heart of our social and working lives. Their practitioners save our lives and keep us in good health, they educate our children, counsel and enlighten us spiritually, advise us on our legal entitlements, manage our money, assist us in running our businesses, help us complete our tax returns, design our homes, and much more. When we are in need of expert guidance on issues that matter to us, we turn naturally to the professions and draw on their members' knowledge and experience.

The professions are of great economic significance. Some are vast. In the United States, for example, almost $3 trillion was spent on healthcare in 2013.[1] This is more than the GDP of all but three other countries in the world. The professions provide employment for hundreds of millions of people. In the United Kingdom, for instance, healthcare and education each employ more people than any other sector, apart from retail.[2] Some professional firms are giants. The 'Big 4' accountancy firms have combined annual global revenue of more than $120 billion. This means that these four businesses alone have a turnover greater than the GDP of the sixtieth-richest country in the world. Certain professions are more important in some countries than others. The legal services market in the United Kingdom, for example, is the largest in Europe, and is responsible for over one-quarter of the total value of the European market.[3]

Beyond their social and economic significance, being a professional, for many practitioners, is seen to be a labour of love and not simply labour for a wage. It is considerably more than holding down a job. Many of the most fulfilled professionals refer to their daily activities as a calling or vocation: not so much a job as a way of life. For the country vet, the village teacher, the local doctor, and the rural lawyer, to pick a few parochial illustrations,

[1] Robert Pear, 'After Slow Growth, Experts Say, Health Spending Is Expected to Climb', *New York Times*, 3 Sept. 2014 <http://www.nytimes.com> (accessed 27 March 2015).

[2] 'Business Register and Employment Survey (BRES) 2013 – Table 1: Broad Industry Group', Office for National Statistics, 25 Sept. 2014. <http://www.ons.gov.uk/ons/taxonomy/index.html?nscl=Employment+by+Industry+Sector#tab-data-tables> (accessed 27 March 2015).

[3] 'Legal profession and the EU', The Law Society, 11 June 2013 <https://www.lawsociety.org.uk/policy-campaigns/government-parliamentary-affairs/miscellaneous-briefings/legal-profession-and-the-eu/> (accessed 27 March 2015).

the overriding aim and ethos is commonly thought to be that of helping fellow citizens. This work is often accompanied by a steady income, even if most professionals have not, traditionally, been the most highly remunerated in society. The professions promise job security and steady career progression. This stability has contributed to the sense of solidity that continues to encourage recipients of professional help to feel they have placed themselves and their problems in the safest of hands.

We want to trust professionals, to see them as upright people whose motives often seem noble, and for them to be the embodiments of honesty, probity, and integrity. We expect that they will act in good faith, and put the interests of those they help ahead of their own. We recognize there are exceptions, of course, so that some professionals are felons rather than paragons, but, by and large, we imagine that the professions are populated by people of good standing.

Our reliance on the professions and the respect that we afford them leads, no doubt, to the considerable status and prestige that their practitioners frequently enjoy. Parents are typically proud of their children when they enter or belong to the professions. This is well illustrated by the joke about the elderly Jewish mother at the seaside with her grown-up son who is struggling in the water; she seeks help by shouting: 'My son, the doctor, is drowning!'

The status and respect seem to incline many non-professional workers to want to be reclassified as belonging to the professions. This is a sentiment that offends many in mainstream professions who enjoy their exclusivity. There can therefore be some snobbery here too, notably amongst higher-handed professionals who expect deference from those they help. There is a more general issue of class here—members of the professions disproportionately belong to the same socio-economic groups and share similar educational backgrounds. In the United Kingdom, for example, 75 per cent of senior judges and 43 per cent of barristers went to independent or fee-paying schools (which educate only 7 per cent of schoolchildren).[4] Almost half of newspaper columnists went to Oxford or Cambridge.[5] In 2011, among undergraduates accepted for medical school, 57 per cent were from the highest three socio-economic groups, and 7 per cent were from

[4] Independent Reviewer on Social Mobility and Child Poverty, *Fair Access to Professional Careers: A Progress Report* (2012), 32 and 4. [Full publication details for book titles are provided in the Bibliography.]

[5] Social Mobility and Child Poverty Commission, *Elitist Britain?* (2014), 10 at <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/elitist-britain> (accessed 27 March 2015).

the lowest three.[6] In a sense, the professions are like a club, admittance to which is permitted only to a select few. Within the club, however, it seems there are various tiers of membership. Surgeons, for example, appear to be part of an elite within the community, while, say, chartered surveyors, if they will forgive us for saying so, are skilled professionals but do not enjoy the same status.

Even those whose occupation cannot formally be said to be one of the professions may nonetheless want to belong to the professions by claiming, for example, that their work is 'professionally' conducted or that their service is 'professionally' delivered. Many people in manual trades, such as plumbing and carpentry, will advertise and assure a 'professional' job done, conveying thereby a sense of proficiency and reliability.

At one time, and especially in the world of sport, the great significance of being professional lay in its stark contrast with that of amateurism. Professionals were paid for their services, but amateurs were not. In some sports, in a different era with a different mindset, it was the amateur who was regarded as an altogether superior specimen. Thus, in the Oscar-winning movie *Chariots of Fire*, when the soon-to-be Olympic gold-medallist Harold Abrahams is being accused by the Master of Trinity College, Cambridge, of having 'adopted a professional attitude' in his training as a sprinter, he responds, 'Perhaps you would rather I played the gentleman and lost?' To this, the Master replies, 'To playing the tradesman, yes.'[7] In that world, for a gentleman (and invariably the inhabitants were male) to submit to professionalism was somehow to concede defeat, to exhibit an insufficiency of the talent required to prevail while holding down a day job. And so Bobby Jones, one of the finest golfers of all time, and of the same vintage as Abrahams, strongly resisted turning professional and yet managed to win the world's major tournaments, both of amateurs and professionals. Notably, when he retired from competition, aged 28, he became a professional of a different kind—a lawyer.

Over time, with the fact of remuneration came an assumption and a reality of superior performance. Professionals, after all, could devote all their waking hours to their sport, while amateurs, even if they had indulgent employers, squeezed their training and practice into their daily working

[6] Independent Reviewer on Social Mobility and Child Poverty, *Fair Access to Professional Careers* (2012), 44.

[7] *Chariots of Fire* (1981), at <http://www.imdb.com/title/tt0082158>.

schedules. So too with our professions: now, in critical times, we do not wish to rely on hobbyists or dilettantes. The common conception of the professions has changed radically.

That said, the professions are not free from criticism from the recipients of their work. They are commonly charged with being elitist, they are frequently regarded as unaffordable, and cynics cite their use of jargon as one of many illustrations of how they mystify and ring-fence their disciplines, so that only professionals are able to serve.

This, then, is the everyday conception of the professions. They weave their way—pervasively, invaluably, indispensably—through society, even if they are sometimes regarded with scepticism. And we see these stereotypes reinforced in our literature, art, cinema, theatre, in our media, and in everyday conversation. On this view, the main challenge facing the professions, it is commonly thought, is to streamline, polish, and modernize an institution that is in place for the duration.

Our position is different. We contend that the professions are on the brink of transformation. As currently constituted, they face problems that they seem unable to solve. Before we identify these problems (section 1.7) and unpack the evidence of change (in Chapter 2), some deeper analysis is required—to help us grasp, more formally, the chief characteristics of the professions, how they came to be, and why they enjoy a privileged arrangement in society.

1.2. The scope of the professions

How do we identify professionals and empower them? In the previous section we outline everyday conceptions of the professions and professionalism. But what do experts on the professions think? Over the past eighty years or so, a formidable academic literature on the professions has built up. Alongside practitioners from within the professions, great armies of theorists have become fascinated with the subject—sociologists, economists, historians, philosophers, psychologists, and many more. Given that one of our main claims is that the days of the traditional professions are numbered, we should be very clear about the nature of the people and institutions that are in our crosshairs.

The first fact to note is that the experts who have written on the subject disagree amongst themselves over what a profession is. While no one can

sensibly question that doctors, lawyers, and accountants belong to the professions, there can be heated discussion, for example, over whether, say, journalists merit the same honorific. In the course of our research, we interviewed several of the world's most senior management consultants, and they shared the view that management consulting is not a profession, largely because anyone can set up a business and trade as a consultant (we return shortly to this underlying question of exclusivity). Similarly, an eminent professor from one of the world's most prestigious universities said that he did not consider that he or his academic colleagues belonged to a profession, even though the professoriate was one of the first recognizable professional groupings.

In 2009, in a report for the British government, it was said that there were more than '130 different professional sectors' in the United Kingdom.[8] In the course of our research, when we mentioned this statistic it was often met with deep concern, not least by members of the longer-established professions. Can it really be, for example, as that document maintained, that 'local government' is a profession? And if not, why not? This, as hinted earlier, is the problem of scope—it is not at all clear where the boundaries of the professions lie, nor in accordance with what criteria they can be delimited. So long as they are safely in the professional camp, these sceptics of a liberal interpretation of 'professions' may well feel inclined to draw the limits quite tightly.

There is clearly a definitional or conceptual problem here. According to Eliot Freidson, an eminent sociologist writing in 1986, effort expended in defining the professions 'has plagued the field for over half a century'.[9] Nor does any consensus seem to have emerged since then. Indeed, some thinkers doubt whether a tight definition of the professions is even possible.[10] One authority has discarded the exercise of defining professionals as 'futile',[11] while another has claimed that 'a firm definition of profession is both unnecessary and dangerous'.[12] We have immersed ourselves in a wide range

[8] Panel on Fair Access to the Professions, *Unleashing Aspiration* (2009), 14. Our thanks to Professor Alan Paterson for drawing this report to our attention. See Alan Paterson, *Lawyers and the Public Good* (2012), 7.

[9] Eliot Freidson, *Professional Powers* (1988), 31. Freidson offers 'A Semantic History' of 'Profession' in ch. 2.

[10] See Robin Downie, 'Professions and Professionalism', *Journal of Philosophy of Education*, 24 (1990), 147–59.

[11] David Sciulli, *Professions in Civil Society and the State* (2009), 1.

[12] Andrew Abbott, *The System of Professions* (1988), 318.

of writings, and conclude that the organizational groups that are—or have been, or aspire to become—professions are so diverse, both in substance and in style, that they defy any highly precise single specification. And it is surely to dance on pinheads to quibble over whether one set of necessary and sufficient conditions is superior to another.[13] We do not, therefore, attempt a pat definition of 'the professions'. Nor do we provide an exhaustive list of those groups that we believe deserve the title and those that, in our estimation, do not make the cut. Whether prostitution, for example, can sensibly be called the oldest profession[14] or management consulting the 'newest profession'[15] is an issue we do not debate (at least, not in these pages).

However, because this book looks ahead to a post-professional society,[16] we nonetheless think it is important to isolate the broad features of today's professions and of the people working within these occupations.[17] To do this, we follow Ludwig Wittgenstein's concept of 'family resemblances'.[18] This is the idea that some phenomena appear related not because they have some unique characteristic in common, but instead because they share a range of 'overlapping and crisscrossing' similarities. Four siblings, for instance, may look alike not because they have a particular feature in common but because they share, to different degrees, an overlapping set of similarities.

By analogy, we suggest that members of today's professions, to varying degrees, share four overlapping similarities: (1) they have specialist knowledge; (2) their admission depends on credentials; (3) their activities are regulated; and (4) they are bound by a common set of values. (One qualification should be noted: although the terms 'professionals' and 'the professions' appear alongside one another, they should not be regarded as interchangeable. 'Professionals' are human specialists, while 'the professions' refers to the occupational groups and institutions to which professionals currently

[13] Moreover, the 'characteristics of professional status' change over time, as can be seen in Roy Lewis and Angus Maude, *Professional People in England* (1953), 72–3, where one of their characteristics is a 'Ban on Advertising of Services'.

[14] For readers interested in whether prostitutes have a claim to be regarded as professionals, see Jethro Lieberman, *The Tyranny of the Experts* (1970), 64–6. The phrase the 'oldest profession' is probably derived from Rudyard Kipling's reference to the 'most ancient profession'.

[15] See Christopher McKenna, *The World's Newest Profession* (2006).

[16] We borrow this term from Ivan Illich. See Ivan Illich, 'Disabling Professions', in Ivan Illich *et al.*, *Disabling Professions* (1977).

[17] In thus characterizing the professions, critics may choose to brand us as members of the 'trait' school of theorists—see sect. 1.5. We think our isolation of 'broad features' falls well short of being traitist.

[18] Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* (1958), See also Downie, 'Professions and Professionalism', 147.

belong.) As with family resemblances, sometimes these features are strong, other times they are not, but the loose network of similarities still holds them together.

First, and above all, professionals have knowledge that lay people[19] do not. Doctors, accountants, lawyers, and architects, for example, have technical knowledge of their disciplines that lay people do not have in their heads or at their fingertips. Relative to lay people, professionals are generally regarded as 'expert', although this term is also used within the professions to mark out and recognize those, even amongst specialists, whose knowledge is deepest. In part, the knowledge of professionals is the formal knowledge that can be found in published books, journals, and increasingly online. But the knowledge of professionals, as distinct from that of theorists or academics, extends also to practical knowledge. This travels under many names, but can be looked upon as applied knowledge or know-how, and is a close relative of what are often spoken of as 'professional skills'. To be a professional practitioner, therefore, is not simply to know a lot and to have an intimate grasp of the substantive teachings of a discipline. It also requires the ability and the wherewithal to apply this knowledge to help patients, clients, or students, as the case may be. Yet it is not enough that professionals have knowledge and skills. More than this, it is also expected that their knowledge is current, that is, that they have the latest insights and techniques at their disposal. Further, they have the responsibility for extending the boundaries of their disciplines, for generating new ideas and methods, and this is a role often assumed by the academic branches of the professions. It is the role of professionals to curate the knowledge over which they have mastery, on behalf of their professions and the recipients of their services.

A second feature of the professions is that admission tends to depend on credentials. Being knowledgeable or even expert is not sufficient to allow aspirants into the club. Before they are recognized as fully-fledged practitioners who can work independently, professionals are generally required to undergo extensive education, training, and indenture, and be able to demonstrate that they gained sufficient knowledge and practical experience along the way; and that they received adequate supervision. Historically, in some professions, a working apprenticeship and sometimes journeyman experience were enough to qualify for admission. Today, success in written or

[19] We use the term 'lay people' throughout the book. It is not ideal. But we find it the best of a bad bunch of possible terms. For example, we do not like 'ordinary people', 'non-professionals', or indeed the lawyer's 'man on the Clapham Omnibus'.

practical examinations can be required and some formal, scholarly teaching is expected. As well as being robustly credentialed, aspiring professionals tend also to be asked for evidence of their character—of their fitness to serve others, and of their moral fibre, whatever that might be. The written reference of professionals of standing is usually satisfactory evidence.

Thirdly, the activities of the professions are usually regulated—in two broad ways. On the one hand, most professions are granted exclusivity over certain activities. For many commentators, this is their distinguishing feature. Professionals are licensed to undertake particular categories of work. This effective monopoly is granted by law and is generally justified by reference to the protection it affords members of the public. Only doctors can prescribe certain medicines, so that patients can be assured the drugs they consume are not dangerous. Only auditors are authorized to assure the accuracy of the financial statements of public companies, so that shareholders can confidently make investment decisions. Alongside the restricted competition that the state sanctions, the law frequently confers substantial independence or autonomy on individual professions, so that many professions are permitted or even required to regulate themselves. This leads to the second aspect of regulation for the professions—that their work should comply with clearly stated standards of conduct and ethical codes. These regulations cover issues as diverse as confidentiality, insurance, duties of good faith, conflicts of interest, service levels, pricing, complaints, and much more besides. While some professions are indeed self-regulating, others are regulated by independent bodies, and still others are hybrids of these two approaches. Increasingly, lay people sit on regulatory bodies. In any event, professionals invariably belong to professional associations or societies, membership of which requires compliance with their regulations. Sometimes these organizations are themselves the regulators, but often they are not. That the professions are independent and sometimes self-regulated does not mean that they are not publicly accountable. On the contrary, they are subject, for instance, and most notably, to the law of negligence, and the field of professional negligence, it should be noted, is a thriving branch of litigation in many jurisdictions.

The final feature of the professions is that their exponents are ordinarily thought to be bound by a common set of values over and above any formal regulations that apply to them.[20] We would expect all professionals to

[20] As Freidson puts it: 'the claims, values, and ideas that provide the rationale for . . . professionalism.' See Eliot Freidson, *Professionalism* (2001), 105.

confirm, for example, that honesty, trustworthiness, and commitment to serving and reassuring others are at the heart of their work. Others, but not all, would go further and maintain that serving the public good, fulfilling certain social responsibilities, ensuring access to their services, and even some degree of altruism are indispensable components of the professional ethic. Still others want to say that a job in the professions should be 'a career of human significance . . . in terms of human welfare and advancement'.[21] There is debate over remuneration—some expect only reasonable rewards, while others regard their professional service as no more than one type of business service, so that profit-seeking is not just possible but central to their work. It is less debatable that many people are attracted to the professions and are proud to remain practitioners because their work is regarded as the province of people of good standing, they are held in high esteem by the public, and their endeavours do and should confer status and prestige.

These four sets of similarities give a broad sense of the scope of our current professions. The occupations we discuss in this book share a sufficient number of these similarities to allow us to refer to them all as belonging to the professions. These are the people, practices, and institutions that we claim will largely be replaced in a post-professional society.

1.3. Historical context

However we might choose to characterize or define the professions, profound questions arise from their existence. While, as we note, a diverse collection of scholars and theorists have made the professions their object of study, the literature of the past century and a half is dominated by the work of sociologists and other social scientists. Talcott Parsons, one of the best-regarded of these, puts it this way: 'Comparative study of the social structures of the most important civilizations shows that the professions occupy a position of importance in our society which is, in any comparable degree of development, unique in history'.[22]

Much can be said about this sociological literature. Some of it is rigorous and scholarly, but—if we are honest—much is turgid and tedious. There are not many laugh-out-loud moments. What is certainly not a

[21] William Wickenden, *A Professional Guide for Young Engineers* (1949), 16.
[22] Talcott Parsons, 'The Professions and Social Structure', *Social Forces*, 17: 4 (1939), 457.

chortling matter is that the *recipients* of professional service make relatively few appearances in the sociological works—the patient, client, student, and other users of the professions have received little sociological scrutiny. (There is a contrast here with the management literature on the professions, which is more client-oriented. Much of this work focuses on the professional 'firm', as a dominant mechanism for organizing and delivering professional services.[23])

As we say, this sociological literature is also characterized by deep disagreement (more of this in section 1.5). We immediately encounter this when we try to pin down the origins of the professions. On one view, '[t]he professions . . . have existed from time immemorial . . .'.[24] Others disagree, and insist that the professions owe their birth in large part to the craft guilds, and flourished notably when the Church declined after the Reformation.[25] There are those who instead maintain that the professions were a product of the Industrial Revolution.[26] However, no one seems to be suggesting that human experts are a recent phenomenon. We only need remind ourselves of various well-known names to conclude that specialists have been walking the earth for centuries: Hippocrates, the physician of ancient Greece (fifth century BC); Cicero, the Roman lawyer (first century BC); Maimonides, the Spanish rabbi and physician (twelfth century AD); and Christopher Wren, the celebrated English architect of the Enlightenment (seventeenth century AD). Yet none of these remarkable individuals belonged to professions and to professional bodies of the sort we have in place in the twenty-first century.

According to Andrew Abbott, a leading theorist of the professions, '[t]he nineteenth century saw the first development of professions as we know them today. In England the merging of the apothecaries with surgeons and physicians, the rise of the lower branch of the legal profession, and the appearance of the surveyors, architects, and accountants signaled the change.'[27] We agree with this assessment, but it is also helpful to turn the clock back further and consider the emergence of law, medicine, and divinity as well-settled disciplines and communities in fifteenth-century Europe;

[23] See e.g. David Maister, *Managing the Professional Service Firm* (1993), and Charles Ellis, *What It Takes* (2013).

[24] Thomas Marshall, 'The Recent History of Professionalism in Relation to Social Structure and Social Policy', *Canadian Journal of Economics and Political Science*, 5 (1939), 325.

[25] Lewis and Maude, *Professional People in England*, 17–19.

[26] See e.g. Alexander Carr-Saunders and Paul Wilson, *The Professions* (1933), and Harold Perkin, *The Rise of Professional Society* (1989).

[27] Abbott, *The System of Professions*, 3.

and to look even further back to the twelfth century, to the appearance of architects in the form of master-masons[28] and the establishment of professoriats in various universities. Determining these historical roots of the modern professions is instructive because many of the attitudes and behaviours that underpin what we call the 'grand bargain' (section 1.4) can be traced, in particular, to the era of the guilds, from the late eleventh century onwards. These medieval guilds (mainly merchant guilds and craft guilds) were associations of specialists and artisans involved with the same trade or craft—they came together to set standards, control competition, to look after the interests of their members and families, and to enjoy the prestige of being part of a group of recognized experts. Here, amongst cobblers, bakers, carpenters, and many others, we find early signs of the self-regulation, monopoly, and the hankering after status that continues to prevail in many modern professions.

In the City of London, members of particular guilds could be distinguished from one another by their livery (ceremonial dress), which led to these guilds becoming known as livery companies. It is telling that new livery companies continue to be set up and flourish. For example, the 100th livery company, the Worshipful Company of Information Technologists, was granted livery status in 1992, while the Worshipful Company of Management Consultants became the City's 105th livery company in 2004. This is an illustration of the tendency of some occupations to 'professionalize', that is, to move towards embracing and exhibiting the characteristics of mainstream professions.[29]

If the pun will be forgiven, the Information Technologists and Management Consultants are in good company. Consider the Company of Barber-Surgeons, founded in 1540. This represented a merger, if you will, of the Guild of Surgeons, which was formed in 1368, and the Barbers' Guild, which was granted Royal Charter in 1462. The new Company of Barber-Surgeons stipulated for the first time who was exclusively permitted to undertake certain categories of work (there were some contested areas of overlap, such as the manipulation of necks and, more importantly, the lancing of boils).[30] From these modest origins came perhaps the most prestigious current professional of all—contemporary surgeons.

[28] Lewis and Maude, *Professional People in England*, 16.

[29] For a discussion of professionalizing, see Harold Wilensky, 'The Professionalization of Everyone?', *American Journal of Sociology*, 70: 2 (1964), 137–58.

[30] The new Company enjoyed interesting privileges, such as the annual allocation of the bodies of four executed criminals for dissection—see <http://barberscompany.org>.